Self-Esteem Toolkit

T.M. (TM-002) | For use between sessions | Three tools: The Flip, The Reframe, The Reset | Be honest with yourself -- this works when you use it

TOOL 1: THE FLIP -- HOW SELF-ESTEEM ACTUALLY WORKS

The old model: Feel worthy first, then act worthy. Wait for confidence, then do the brave thing.

The flip: Act worthy first, and the feeling of worth follows. Self-esteem is not something you receive. It is something you **build through esteemable acts** -- actions conducted with integrity, care, and responsibility.

Every time you do one of these, you lay a brick:

Five Categories of Esteemable Acts (your "bricks"):

1. **Showing Up for Yourself:** Keep a personal commitment. Exercise. Eat well. Meditate. Listen genuinely to someone.
2. **Service to Others:** Help someone. Mentor. Volunteer. Show up for someone when it would be easier not to.
3. **Cultivating Your Surroundings:** Organize your space. Be mindful of what media you consume. Build positive environments.
4. **Authentic Expression:** Present yourself honestly. Say what you mean. Dress in a way that feels like you, not like camouflage.
5. **Personal Accountability:** Do the right thing when no one is watching. Hold your boundaries. Own your choices without shame.

The thought is weather. The label is damage. The act is the brick.

Low vs. Healthy Self-Esteem -- Know Where You Stand

DIMENSION	LOW SELF-ESTEEM	HEALTHY SELF-ESTEEM
Mistakes	Severe self-criticism, feelings of personal failure, avoidance of risk	Viewing mistakes as learning, treating yourself with compassion
Boundaries	Weak; saying "yes" to please others at your own expense	Clear and firm; comfortable saying "no" to protect time and energy
Praise	Deflecting compliments, dismissing achievements	Accepting with a simple "thank you" and feeling genuine pride
Decisions	Chronic second-guessing, relying on others to validate choices	Trusting your judgment while remaining open to feedback
Comparison	Constantly measuring against others; envy, inadequacy	Measuring progress against your own past self

TOOL 2: THE REFRAME -- CATCH IT, NAME IT, FLIP IT

When your mood drops or self-doubt spikes, use this template. Write it down -- pen and paper works better than just thinking it.

1. THE TRIGGER: What happened right before the thought?

Example: A customer was rude and I had a judgmental thought about them.

2. THE CRITIC (Automatic Thought): What exact phrase is running in your head?

Example: "I'm such an asshole for thinking that. I'm a judgmental person."

3. THE DISTORTION: What trick is your mind playing?

- **All-or-Nothing:** "If I'm not perfect, I'm a failure."
- **Catastrophizing:** "One bad thought means I'm a terrible person."
- **Mind Reading:** "Everyone can see how judgmental I am."

4. THE EVIDENCE: What are the objective facts?

Evidence supporting the thought:

Evidence contradicting the thought:

Example: I helped my friend, I showed up for therapy, I pulled someone from a river, I have genuine care for people.

5. THE BALANCED REALITY: Fair, realistic substitute statement.

Example: "I had a reactive thought about someone who was being difficult. That was human. It does not define me. I have a track record of care and integrity, and my next act is what builds my worth."

The critic says "you ARE a failure." The coach says "that attempt failed. What's your next move?"

TOOL 3: THE RESET -- SOMATIC TECHNIQUES

When self-criticism triggers an emotional spiral, your nervous system reads it as a physical threat (fight-or-flight). To quiet the mind, you first signal safety to the body.

A. The Physiological Sigh (fastest reset -- 10 seconds)

1. Two quick, deep inhalations through your nose: one deep breath, then immediately a sharp second "top-off" sip of air.
2. One long, slow exhale through your mouth -- as slow as you can.
3. Repeat 2-3 times. This instantly triggers your parasympathetic nervous system and lowers your heart rate.

When to use: The moment you catch a harsh self-label firing. Before the spiral starts.

B. The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Technique

Instead of fighting the thought, redirect your focus outward through your senses:

- **Level 1:** Notice **5 things you can see** around you.
- **Level 2:** Touch **4 distinct textures** nearby (clothes, desk, cool glass, fabric).
- **Level 3:** Listen for **3 distinct sounds**.
- **Level 4:** Identify **2 things you can smell or taste**.
- **Level 5:** Take **1 deep nasal breath**. Clench your jaw lightly for 3 seconds. Release completely. Let shoulders drop.

Why it works: Shifts processing from the hyper-reactive amygdala back to your immediate physical reality. The spiral cannot sustain itself when your attention is anchored in the present.

C. Peripheral Vision Expansion (Open Monitoring)

1. Fix your gaze on a single point on the wall straight ahead.
2. Without moving your eyes, slowly allow your awareness to expand outward -- left and right -- taking in your entire peripheral field of vision.
3. Hold the expanded awareness for 15-30 seconds.

Why it works: Broadening your visual field mechanically disrupts the intense "tunnel vision" associated with stress and stress-hormone production. Your nervous system cannot maintain a fight-or-flight response while in panoramic vision mode.

THE STACK: PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

When a harsh thought fires, use this sequence:

1. **Physiological Sigh** (2-3 breaths) -- stop the spiral in your body first
2. **Anchor** (thumb + forefinger, right hand, one breath) -- activate the circle + tribe + workshop
3. **Read the label** -- what did the critic just print?
4. **Name the distortion** -- all-or-nothing? catastrophizing? mind reading?

5. **Fact-check** -- objective fact or emotional reaction?
6. **Replace** -- write the balanced truth (even just in your head)
7. **Choose the next esteemable act** -- lay a brick. Any brick. Move.

Sigh. Anchor. Read. Name. Check. Replace. Build.

If a spiral feels overwhelming:

1. Physiological Sigh (2-3 times) + anchor (thumb + forefinger)
2. 5-4-3-2-1 grounding if the sigh is not enough
3. Email Jeeth: jeeth@vrishihypno.com (24-hour response)
4. If urgent: call or text **988** (24/7)